

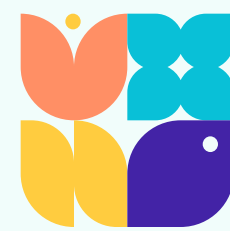
2025

BROAD CHALLENGES, UNIQUE STRENGTHS

STATE OF UX IN HAWAI'I



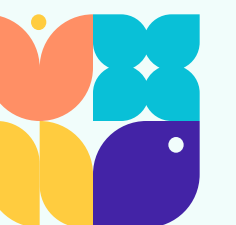
With community, place-based values, and giving at our core, UX in Hawai‘i stands poised to bring unique contributions to the globe and the people we serve.



Executive summary

We're a diverse community of makers and designers organizing ourselves around the charge of delivering superior user experiences.

Through this community-driven research, we learned that the field of UX in Hawai'i is even more dynamic and rooted than when we had canvassed in 2022. At the same time, we still face many challenges.



Research purpose

- Learn about the landscape and market
 - Who are the practitioners?
 - What companies embrace UX as a practice?
 - What challenges exist?
- Hear about the type of support UXHI should provide

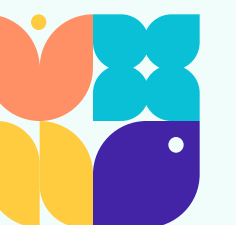
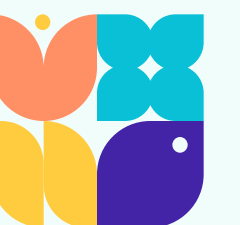
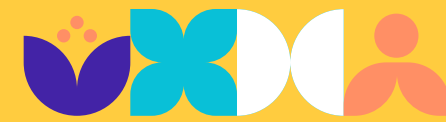


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RESEARCH OVERVIEW



Methodology

We used a mixed-methods, community-driven approach, synthesizing and triangulating qualitative and quantitative data.

57

Participatory action research

2024 UXHI Conference attendees were invited to be researcher-participants in a 45-minute session: sharing, collecting, and synthesizing insights in small groups.

37

Survey responses

From November 2024 to January 2025, we received responses from UX and business communities utilizing Tally.so.

10

In-depth interviews

In 45-minute sessions, interviewees discussed opportunities and challenges for UX in Hawai'i, and shared advice for UX professionals.

Research by and with our community

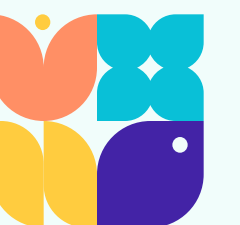
Inspired by the stance of Participatory Action Research, where communities can be researchers of their own contexts, we hoped to go beyond description in our research by inviting the UXHI community to participate as researchers at the 2024 UXHI Conference.

In a session with 57 participant-researchers, we asked our community to explore the following questions:

- What is working well for UX in Hawai‘i?
- What is not working well for UX in Hawai‘i?
- What can we do as individuals and as a community?

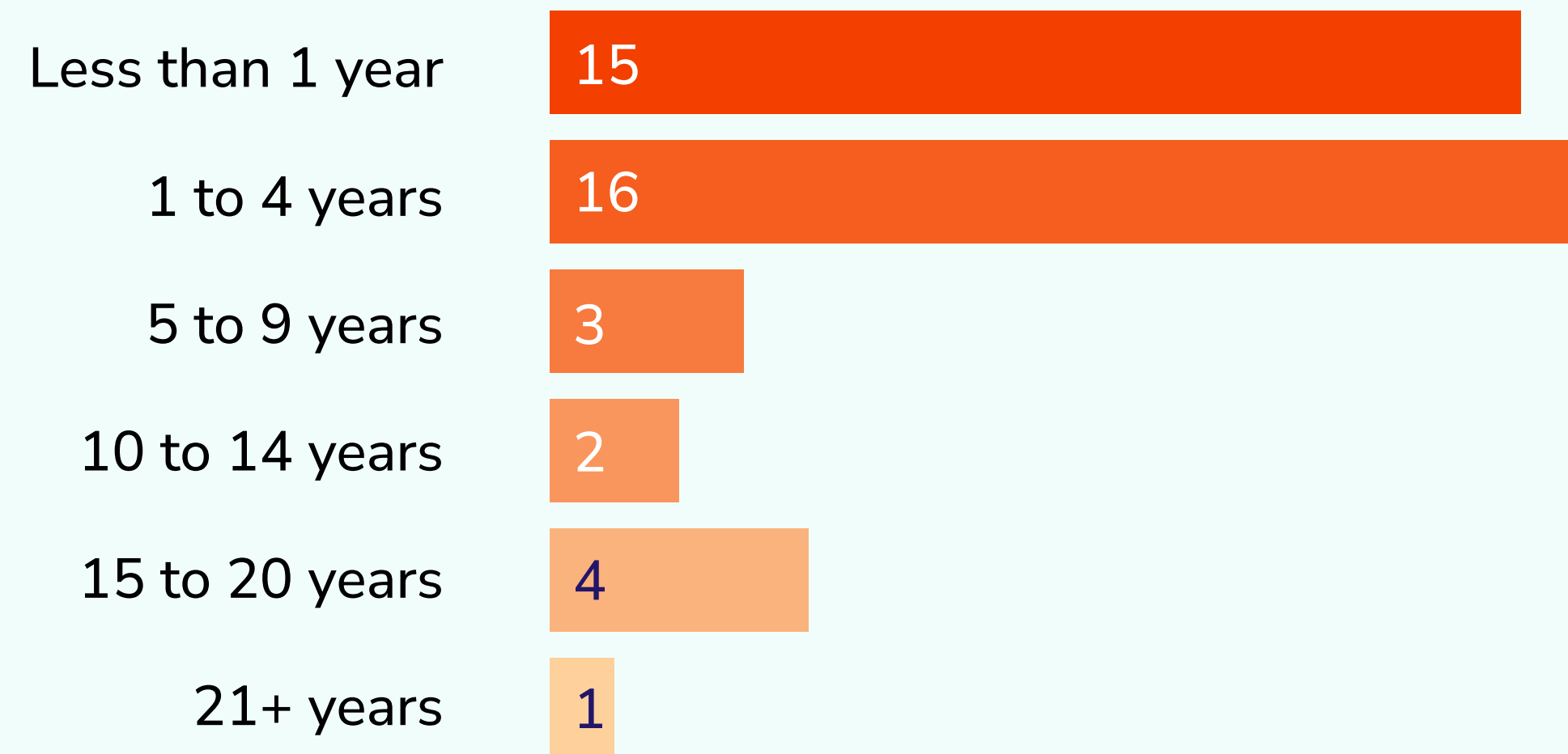
Participant-researchers were invited to discuss these questions in groups of 3, then share with another group of 3 and find the commonalities in their discussions.

In this way, participants helped gather and synthesize data from their discussions.

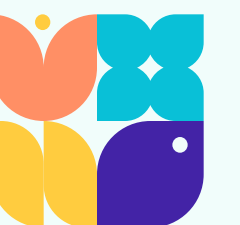
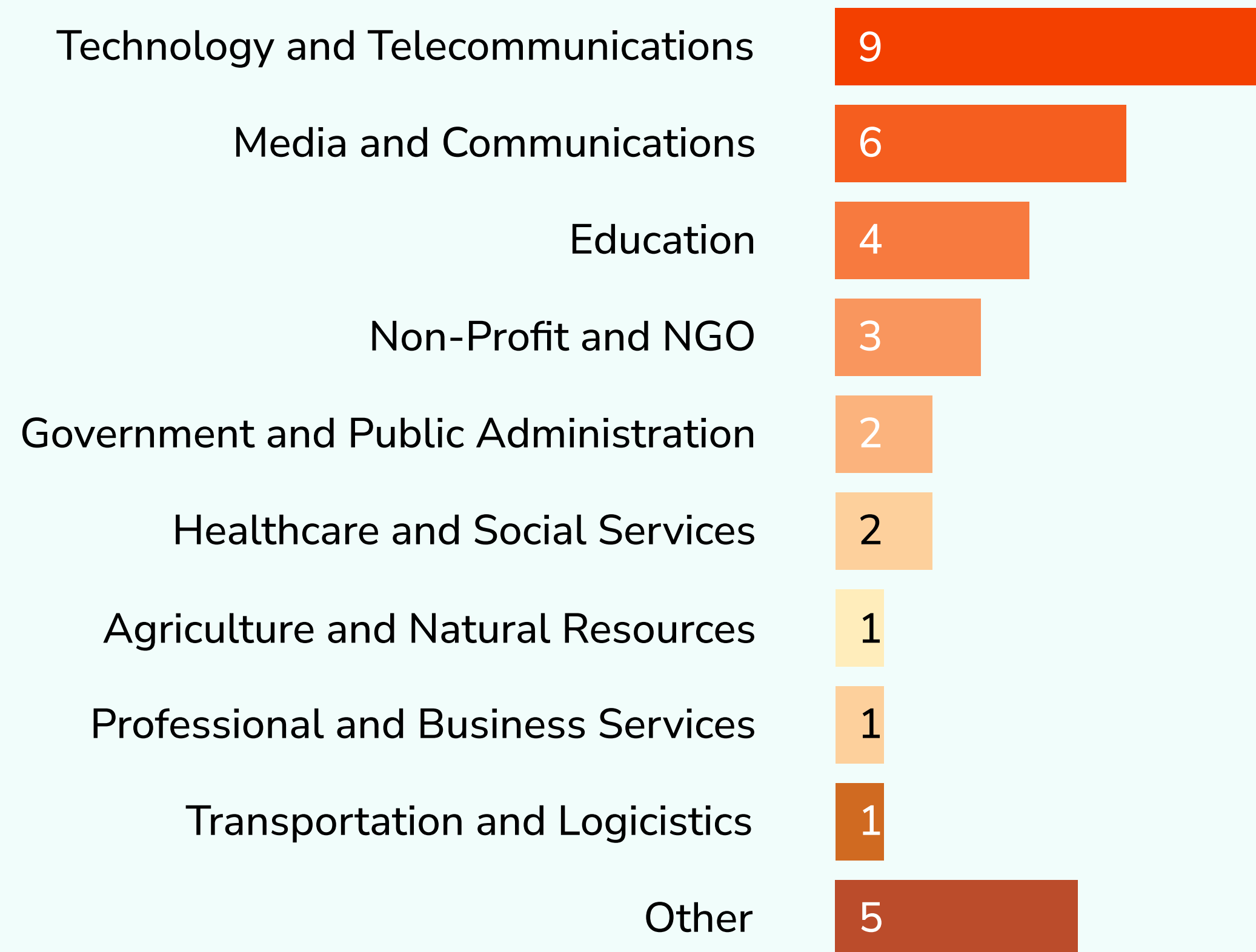


Researcher-participants' answers

How long have you been practicing UX?



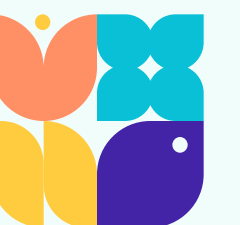
Which industry do you work in?



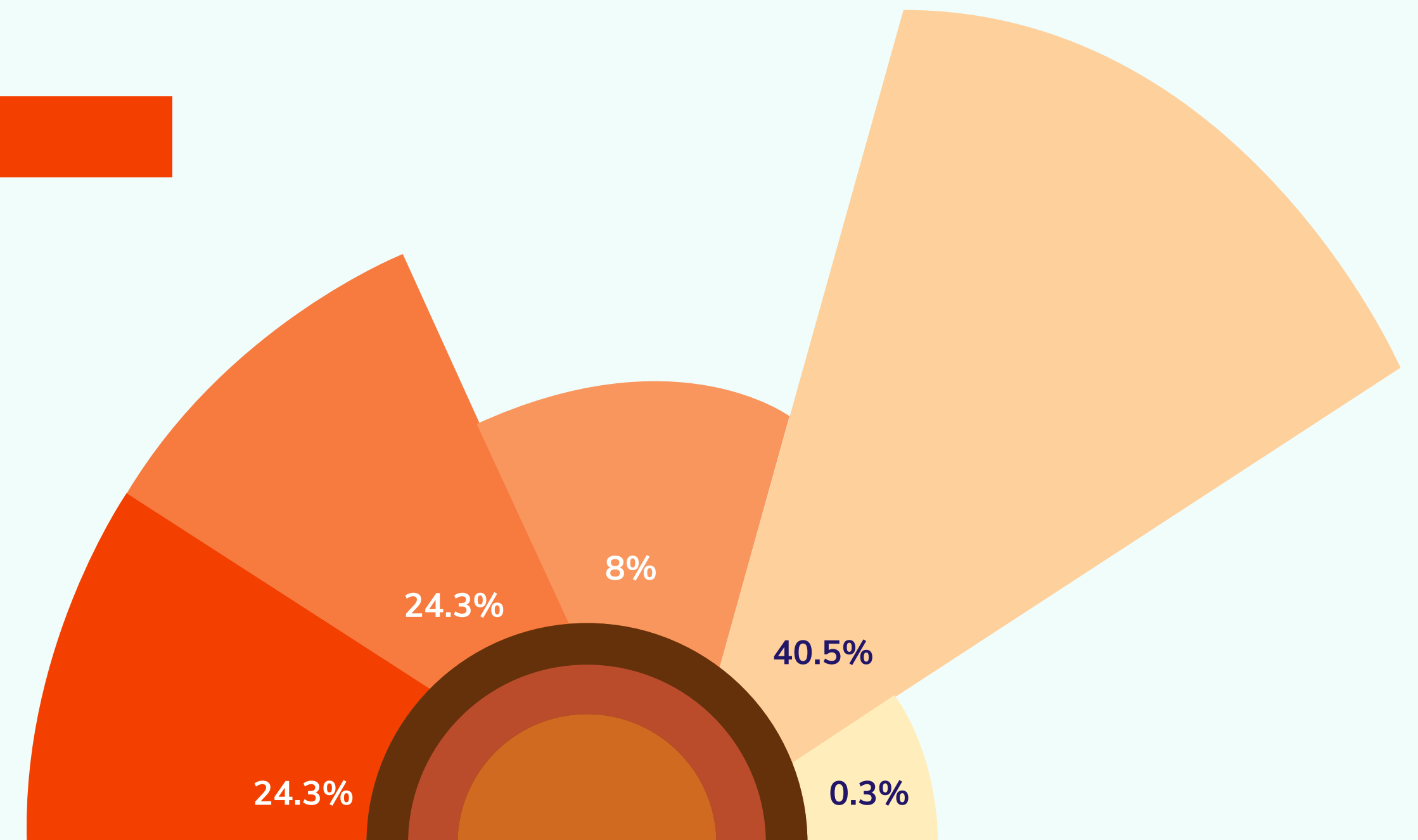
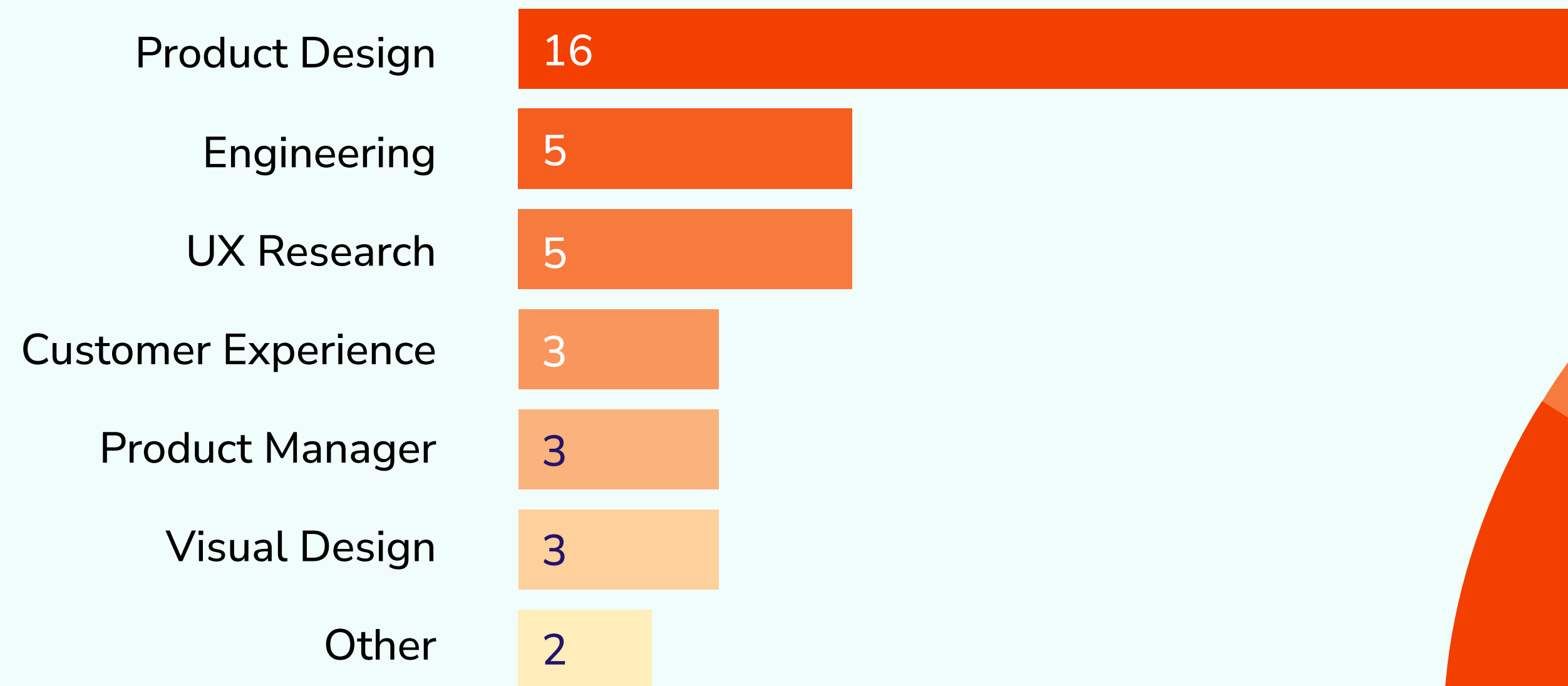
Limitations to survey data

Our goal isn't to generalize, but to explore and start a conversation.

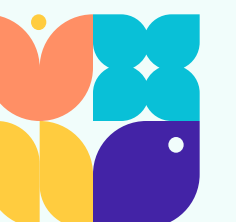
- Relied on **convenience sampling**
- UXHI Slack workspace general membership: around **300** members
 - Average monthly active members during time of data collection (Dec 2024–Jan 2025): **116–138**
 - Total survey responses on the community survey: **37**
- Data collection timeline
 - Participatory session: Oct 2024
 - Interviews: Nov 2024–Jan 2025
 - Community survey data collection: Dec 2024–Jan 2025
- Due to minimal responses on a business survey, we did not include it in our analysis.



Current job title and job level



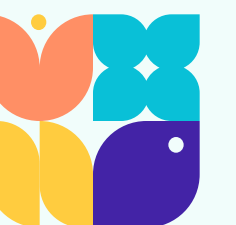
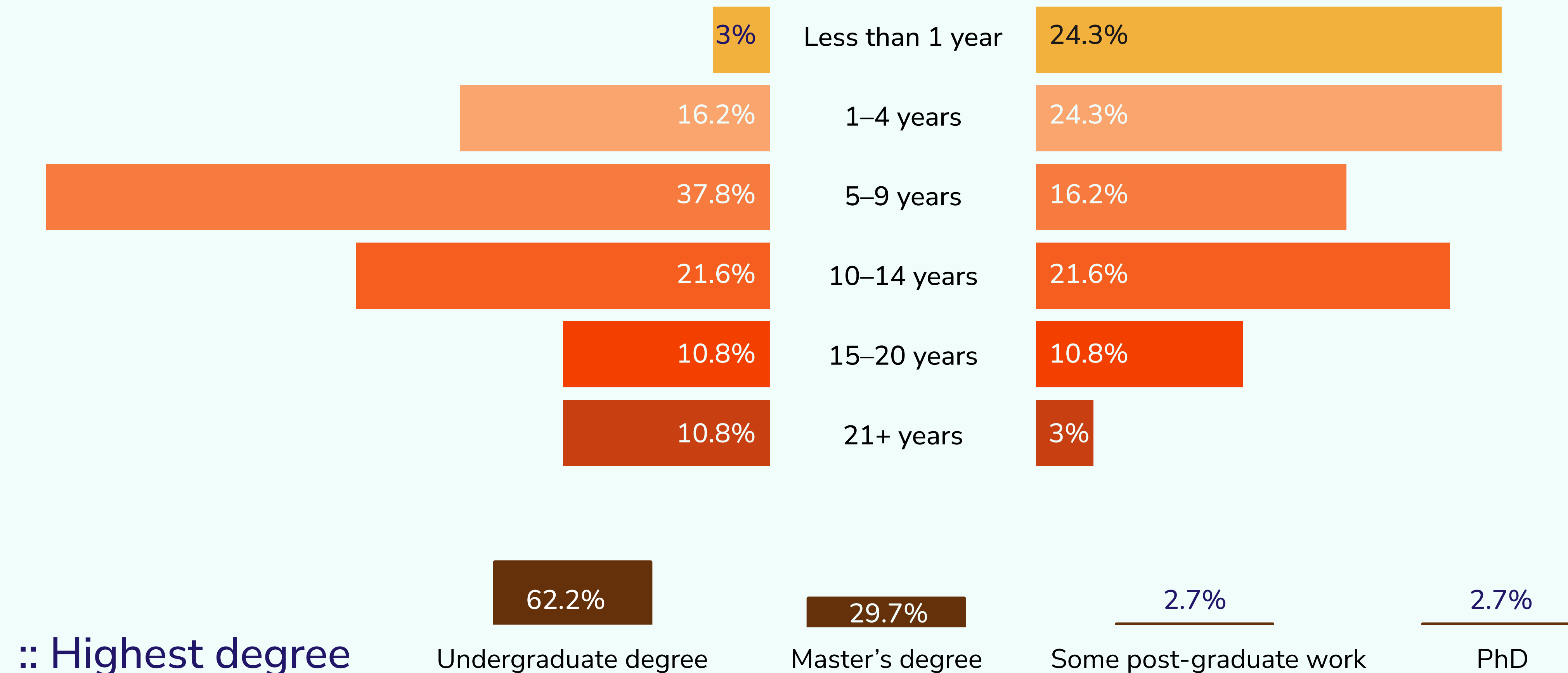
- VP, Manager, Director
- Senior Level
- Mid-Level
- Individual Contributors, Entry, Junior, Associate
- Contractor/Temp



Work experience and education

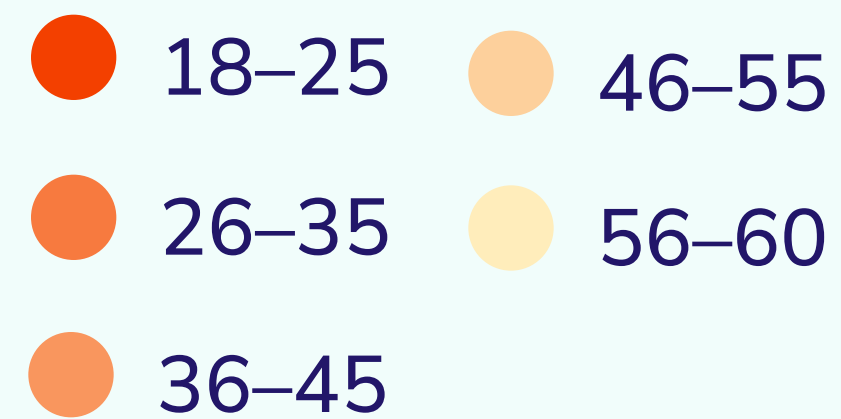
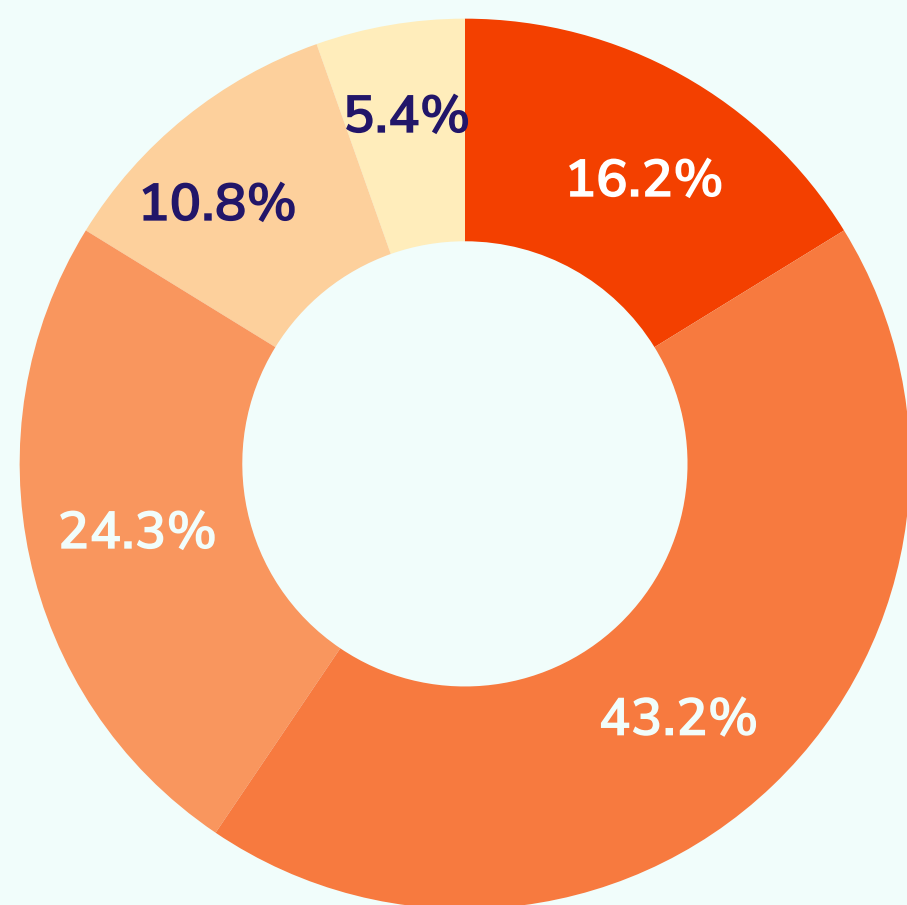
:: Overall work experience

:: UX-specific work experience

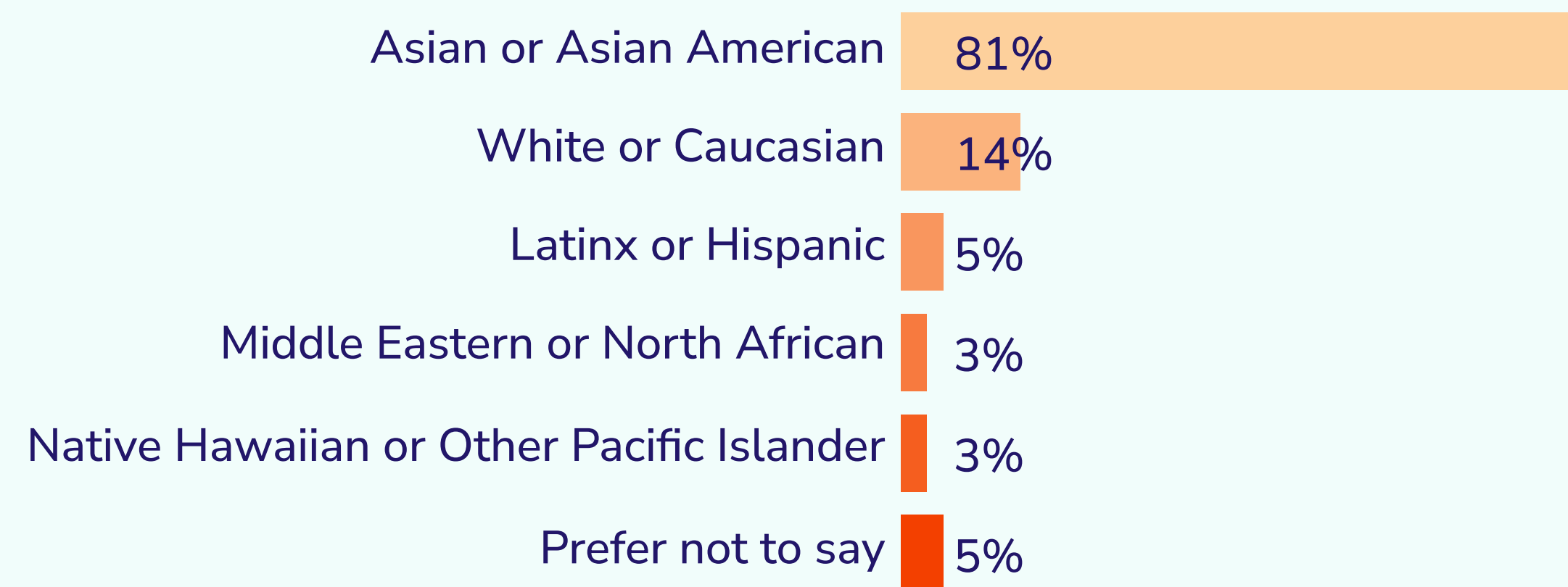


Demographics

:: Age

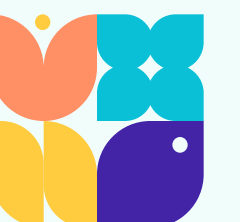
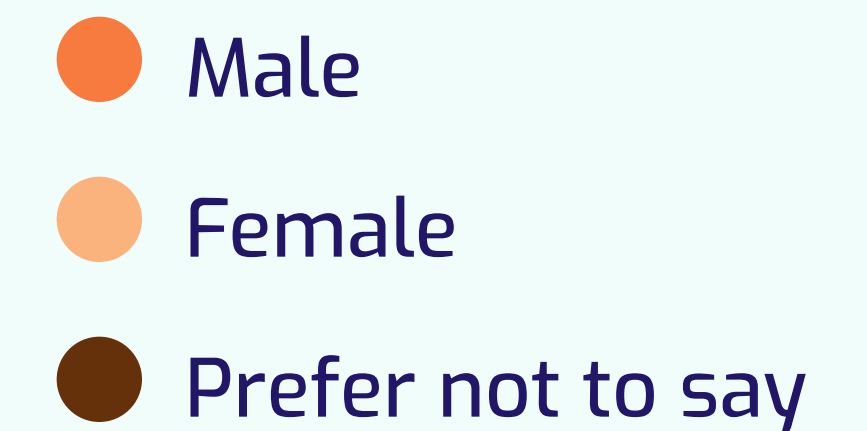
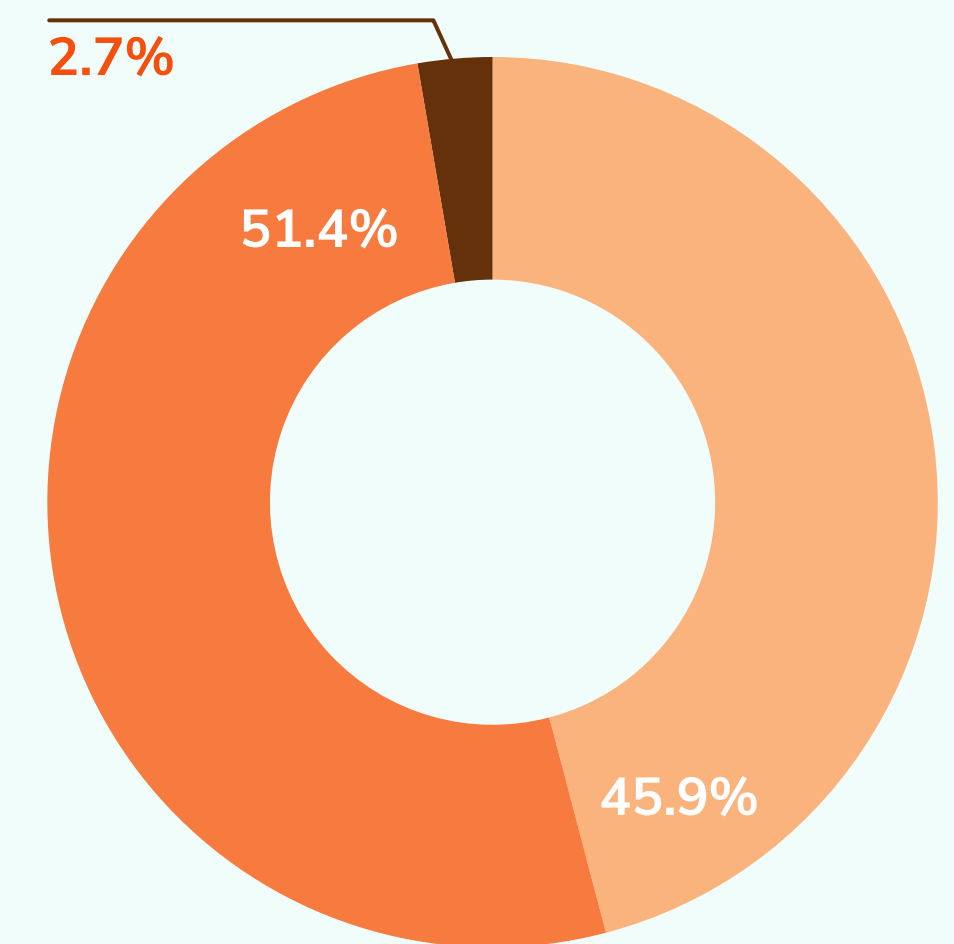


:: Ethnic background



The percentages above reflect the number of participants who identified with each race/ethnicity. Therefore, the total sum of percentages is greater than 100% because many participants are multiethnic or multiracial.

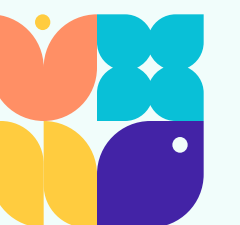
:: Gender



In-depth interviews

In the same vein of gathering insights both about UX practitioners and their companies, we sought to interview a minimum of 5 UX practitioners in individual contributor roles, and 5 working for companies based in Hawai'i who were in hiring roles. Our interview protocol was structured around the following main questions:

- What are the biggest challenges that you or your company face in serving your customers?
- How does your company gather product/service usability or user experience feedback from customers?
- Where do you see opportunities for the UX field in Hawai'i?
- What is your advice for UX professionals based in Hawai'i?
- What do you see as unique about the business ecosystem and user experience needs in Hawai'i?





**Common themes emerged
from a triangulation of all
data gathered...**



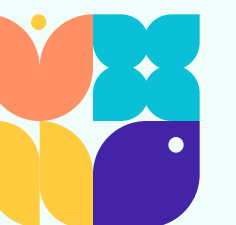
**First, to level-set: How
does our UXHI community
define UX?**

How do participants describe UX design?

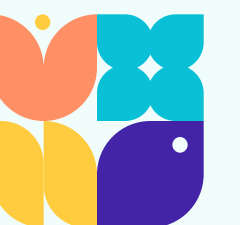
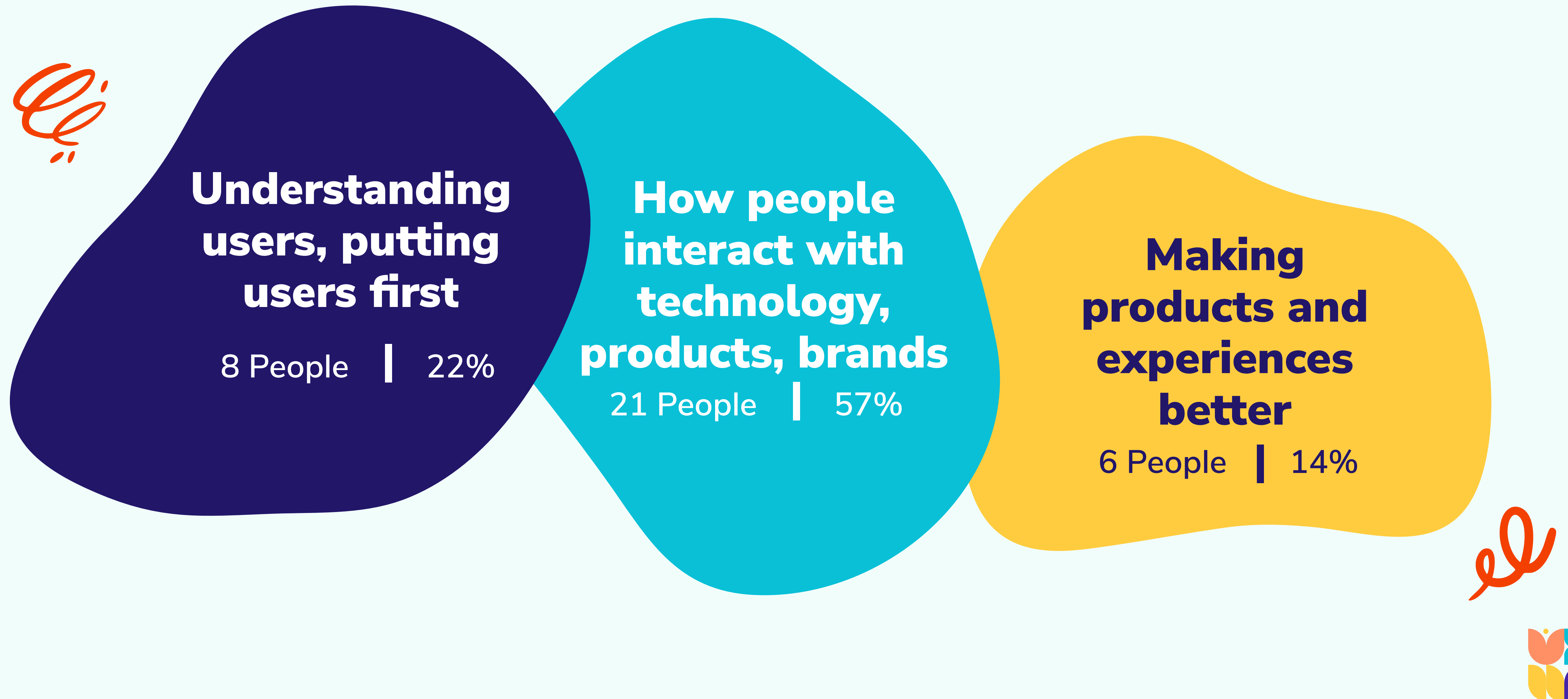
“The conscious and subconscious feelings, thoughts, and behaviors experienced by a user who is using a product to achieve an outcome”

“UX is how the company/organization is represented to the world. It can embody the organization's values, missions, as well as its commitments. It indirectly or directly publicly contributes to how its products and services is received, and therefore contributes to the organization's success”

“Bringing a human touch to digital experience”
“Understanding who you're designing for and what needs to be designed. Understand the problem, what that solution looks like, and it usually involves how it works and how someone would interact”



How do survey respondents understand UX?



STRENGTHS



We are stronger together

UX in Hawai'i is uniquely defined by its strong sense of community and connection. The values noted in our 2022 report have held steadfast.

Woven throughout responses, our community shared the importance of staying true to Hawai'i's cultural values.

Key values highlighted by our community

Aloha 'Āina
LOVE OF THE LAND

Mālama 'Ōhana
CARE FOR ONE ANOTHER

Nā Waiwai Hawai'i
TREASURED VALUES



Aloha ‘Āina

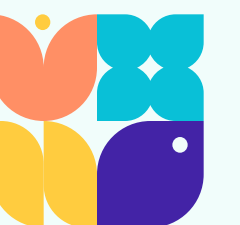
Love of the land

“If we're zooming out generally, there's a baseline collectiveness because of the high level of diversity... So from that, there could be deeper levels of empathy and connection. Potentially, I feel like that could be leveraged.”

– Interview, UX Manager

“‘Āina based culture makes HI UX different.”

– Interview, Founder & CEO



Mālama ‘Ohana

Care for one another

“SF is so competitive, but in HI, everyone is willing to help each other.

Rather than seeing each other as competitors, the Hawai‘i community helps and lifts each other in knowledge sharing.”

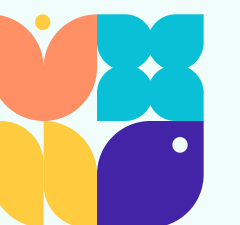
– Interview, Designer-Founder & Executive Director

“Community - Most connected welcoming organized”

“There is a lot of information sharing / connection to resources”

“Kindness + UX”

– Noted by participant-researchers



Nā Waiwai Hawai'i

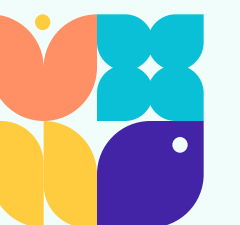
Treasured values

“Incorporation of local indigenous knowledge - here we **can't default to established patterns** as much. **Cultural competency** as a competitive advantage.”

– Noted by participant-researchers

“Hawai'i comes from a different approach to UX Design (i.e. culture, history) - the **process is different than the continent** or other places”

– Noted by participant-researchers



Yet we also often heard...

“How do we compete with other places?”

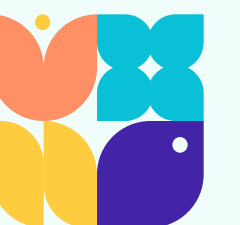
We heard recommendations to create opportunities for learning how to pitch to Continental U.S. companies.

“Hawai‘i embodies aloha spirit and good UX is synonymous.”

We’d like to ask our community:

How might we champion our uniqueness in this competitive space?

How might we problematize this idea of the “mainland being the benchmark”?



CHALLENGES

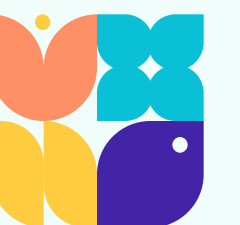
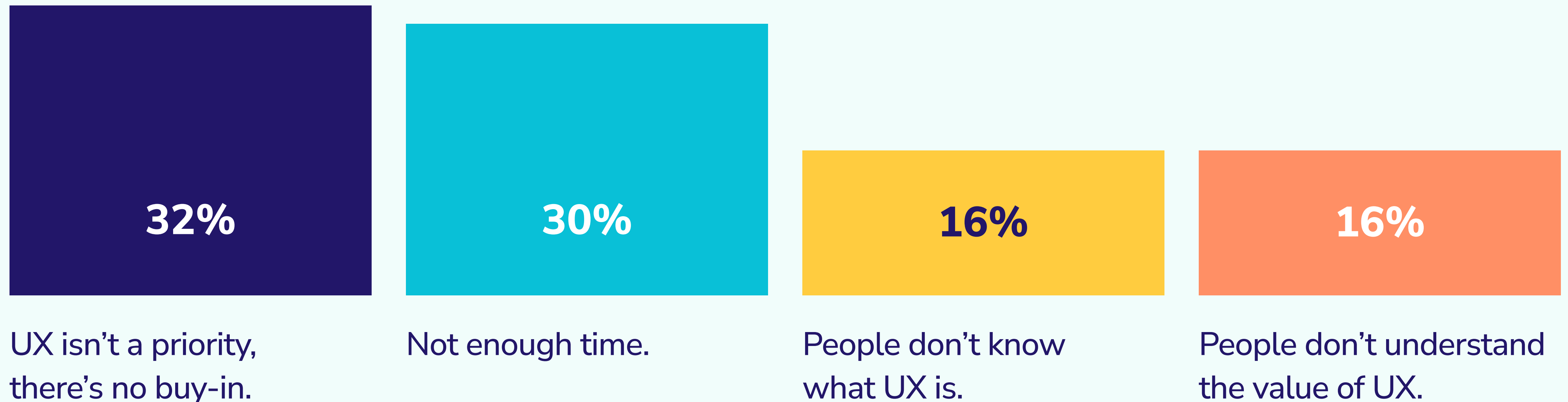




Low prioritization of UX resourcing

People may not be aware of UX

What challenges do you face as a UX practitioner or when implementing UX design practices within your organization?



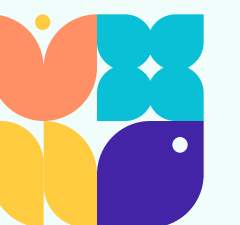
Organizations may not value UX

“My organization **does not understand the value of UX research or design** and thinks of it as making something ‘look good.’... My company **thinks that the most important people on a software project are the devs** and everyone else is just supporting them.”

– Survey, UX/UI Design Lead at a Hawai‘i-based company

“One of the main challenges I face as a UX practitioner is the lack of organizational focus on UX and UI. The emphasis is often placed on backend functionality, with less priority given to the user interface and overall user experience.”

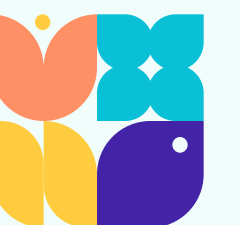
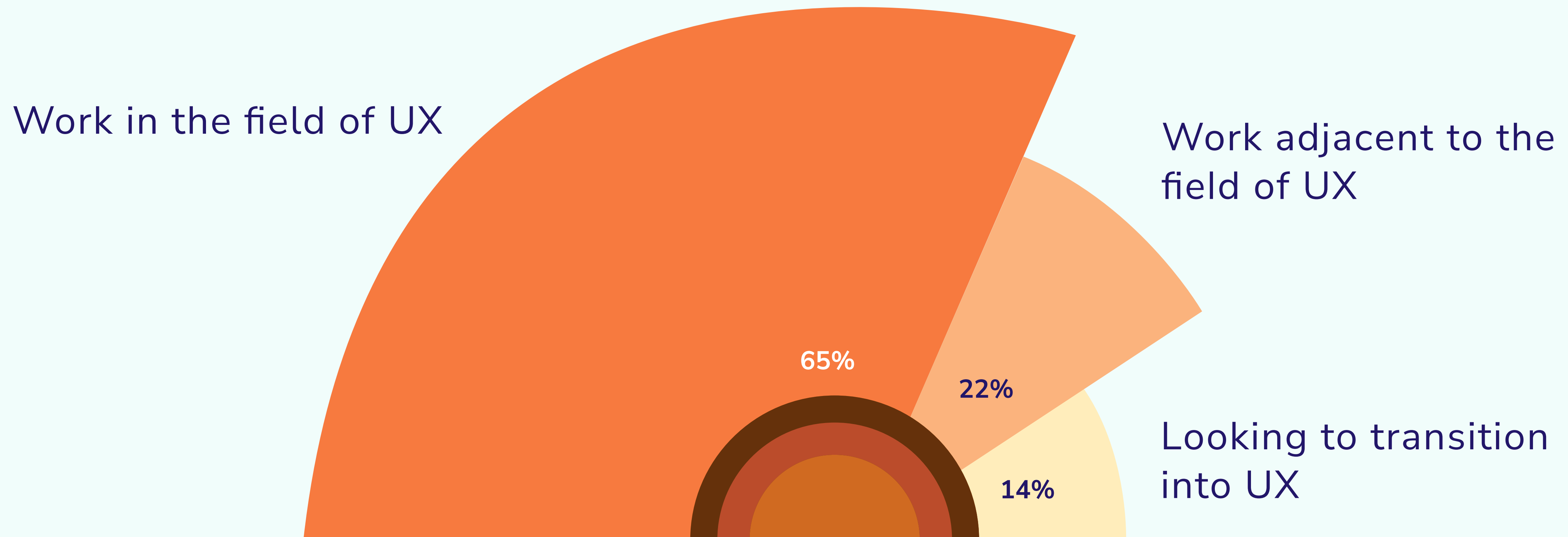
Source: Survey, UX Designer, at company outside of Hawai‘i





**UX skills
are hard won**

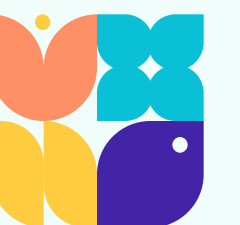
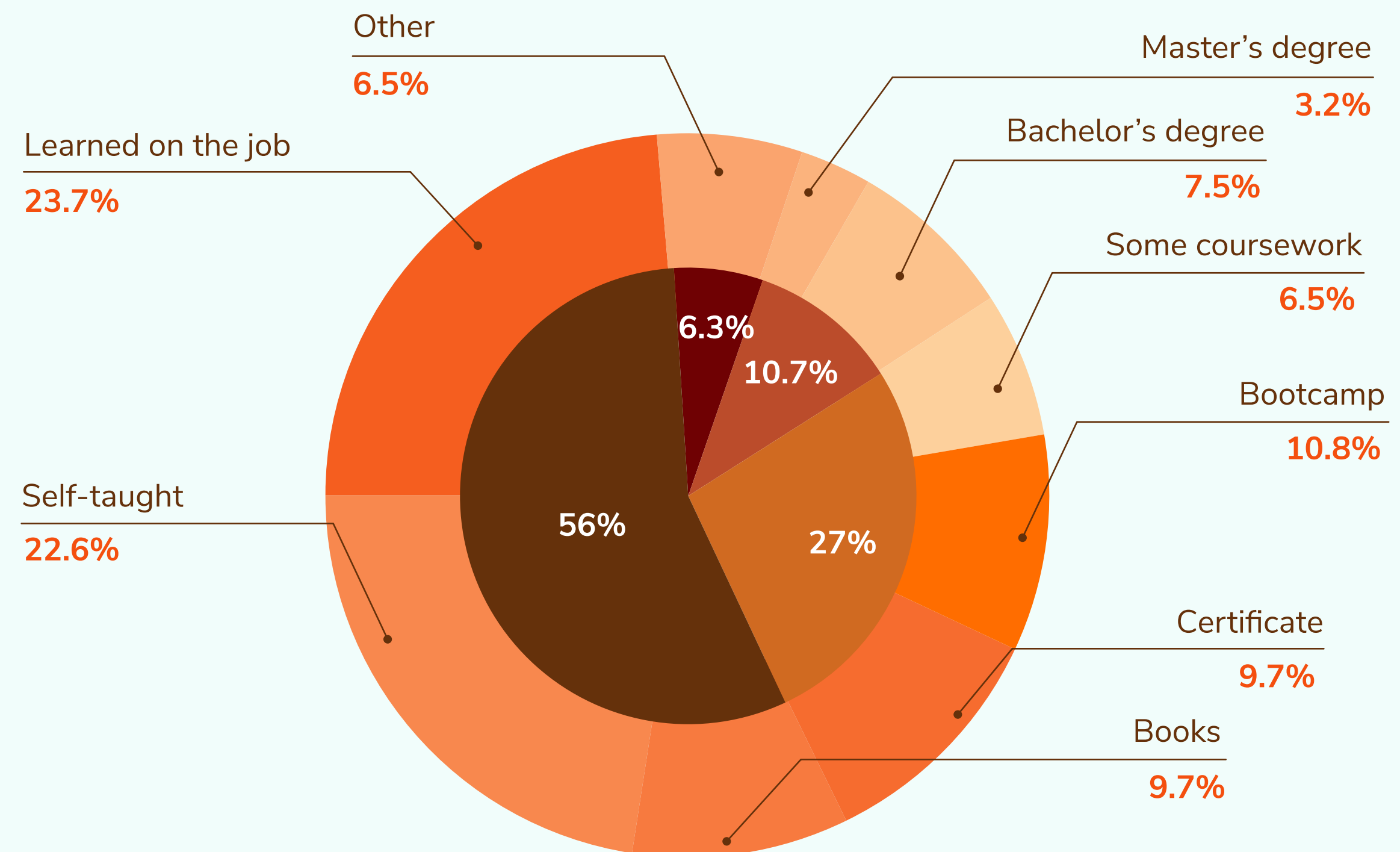
More than half of our respondents work in UX, while many work adjacently or are looking to transition their career



People come to UX via many pathways and may need upskilling or re-skilling

How did you learn about UX?

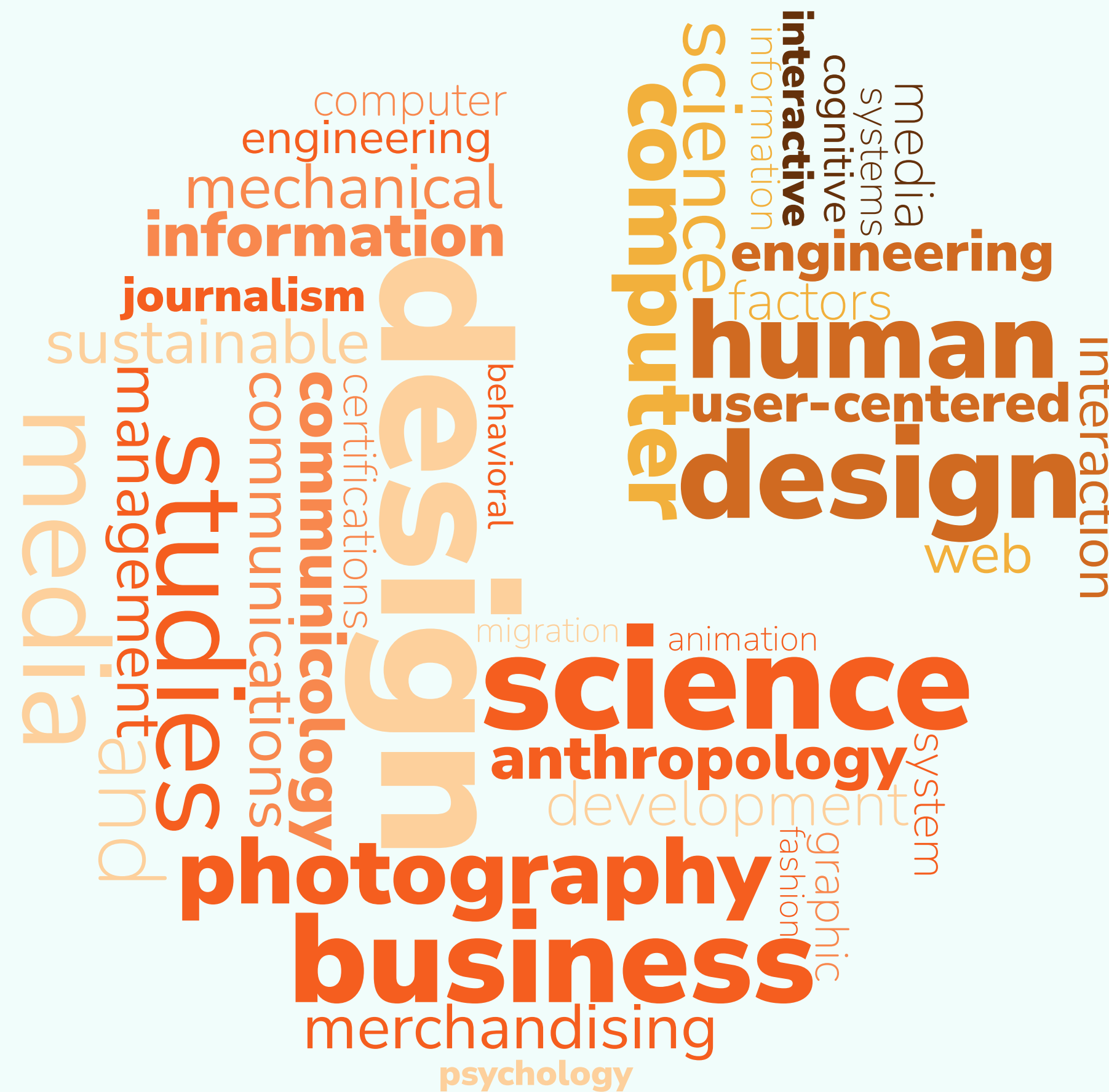
- **56%** of respondent practitioners were either self taught, learned on the job, or from books.
- **27%** came to UX through either certificates, bootcamps, or some coursework.
- Only **10.7%** were formally educated in degree programs.



Of those with a university degree, 72% said their degree is not directly related to UX

Degrees directly related to UX

Degrees NOT directly related to UX



Even those who learned about UX through a degree or certificate program wished for more experience

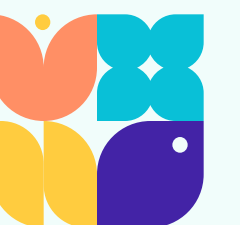
What do you wish was taught in your educational program?

5 out of 26

Working with other roles
(engineers, clients, etc.)

5 out of 26

More real-world/
hands-on experience



UX skills are hard won—and we heard a need for education

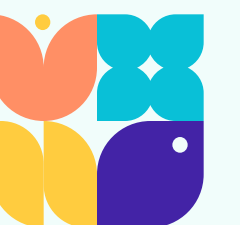
What can we do as individuals and as a community?

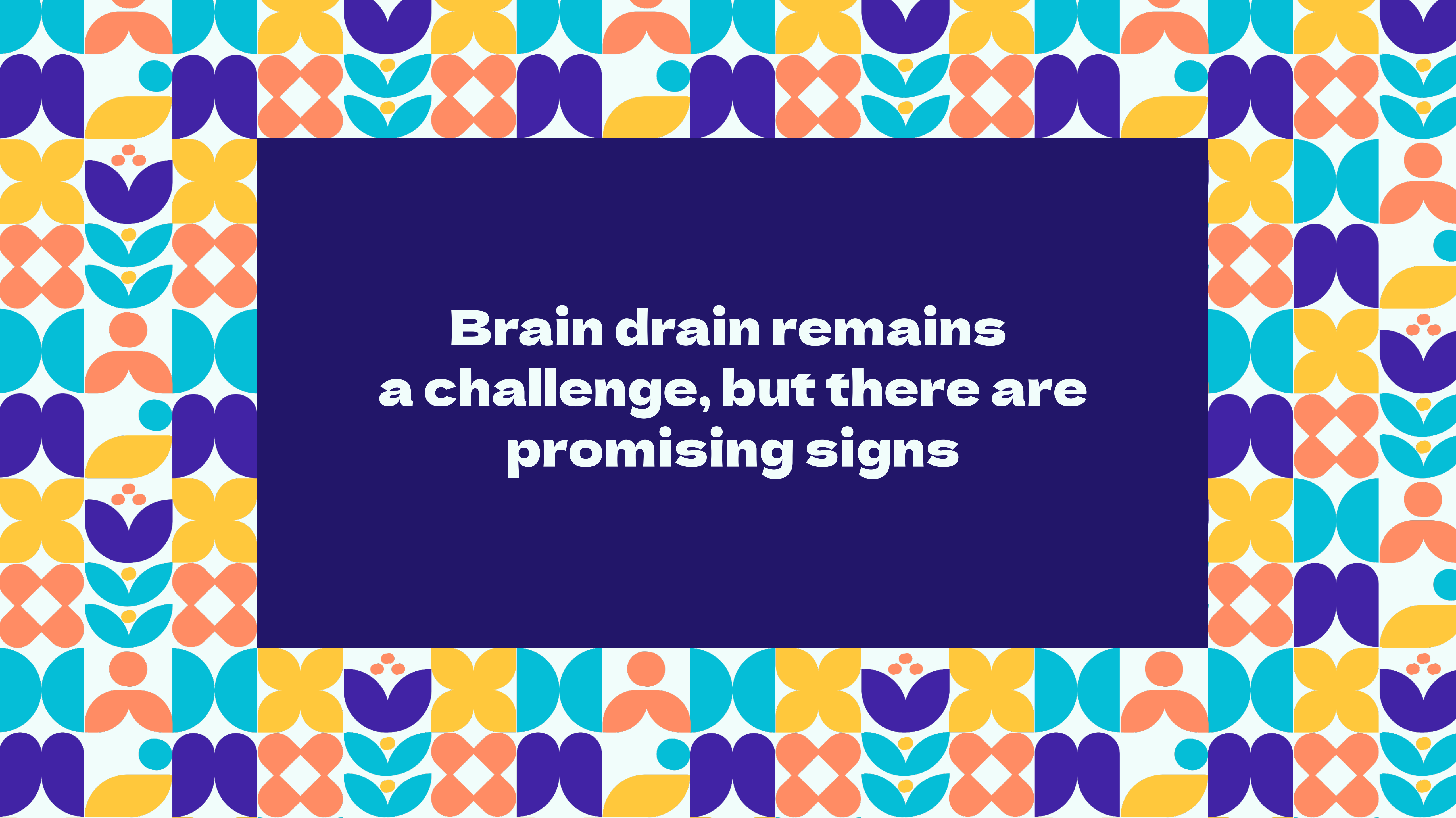
“More education – within the community about UX, skill-building”

– Noted by participant-researchers

“Providing better education & opportunities to UX professionals & trainees”

– Noted by participant-researchers

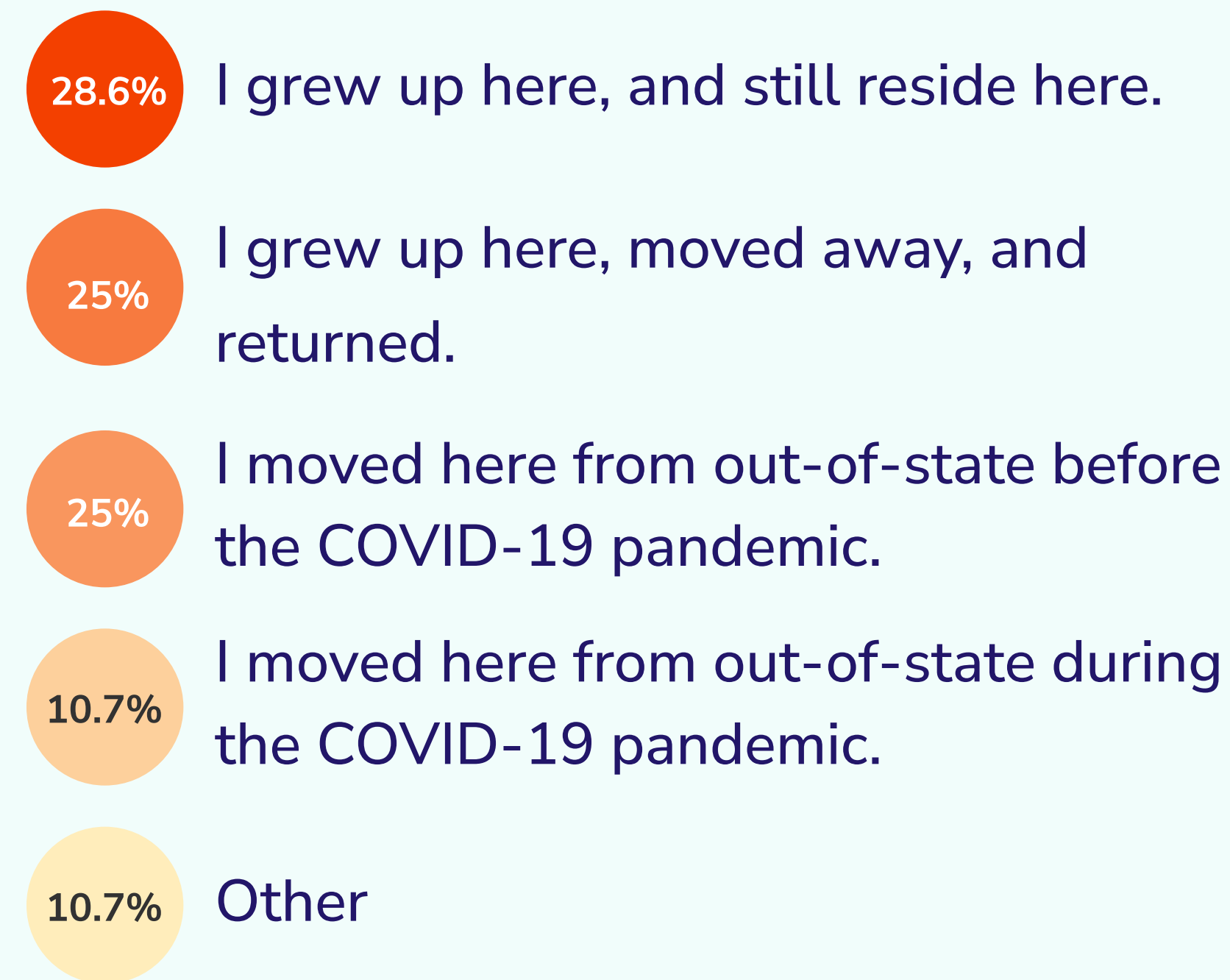




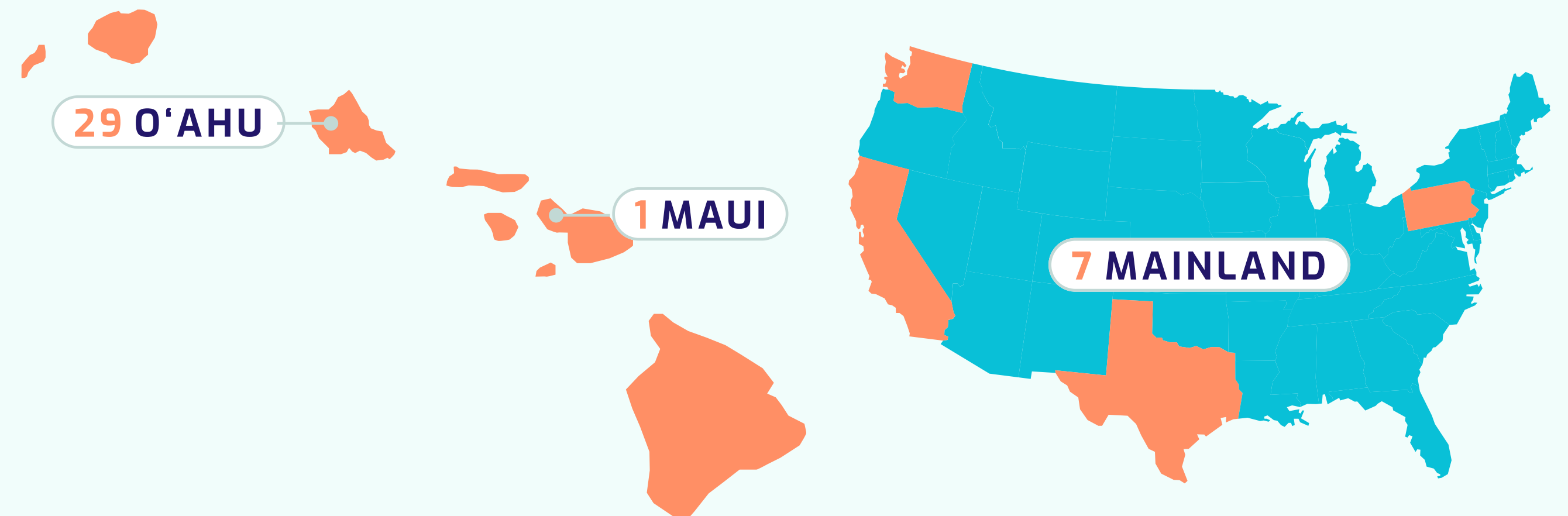
**Brain drain remains
a challenge, but there are
promising signs**

Not all survey respondents intend to stay in Hawai‘i

:: History living in Hawai‘i?

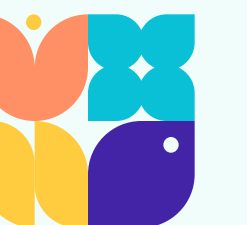


:: Current residence

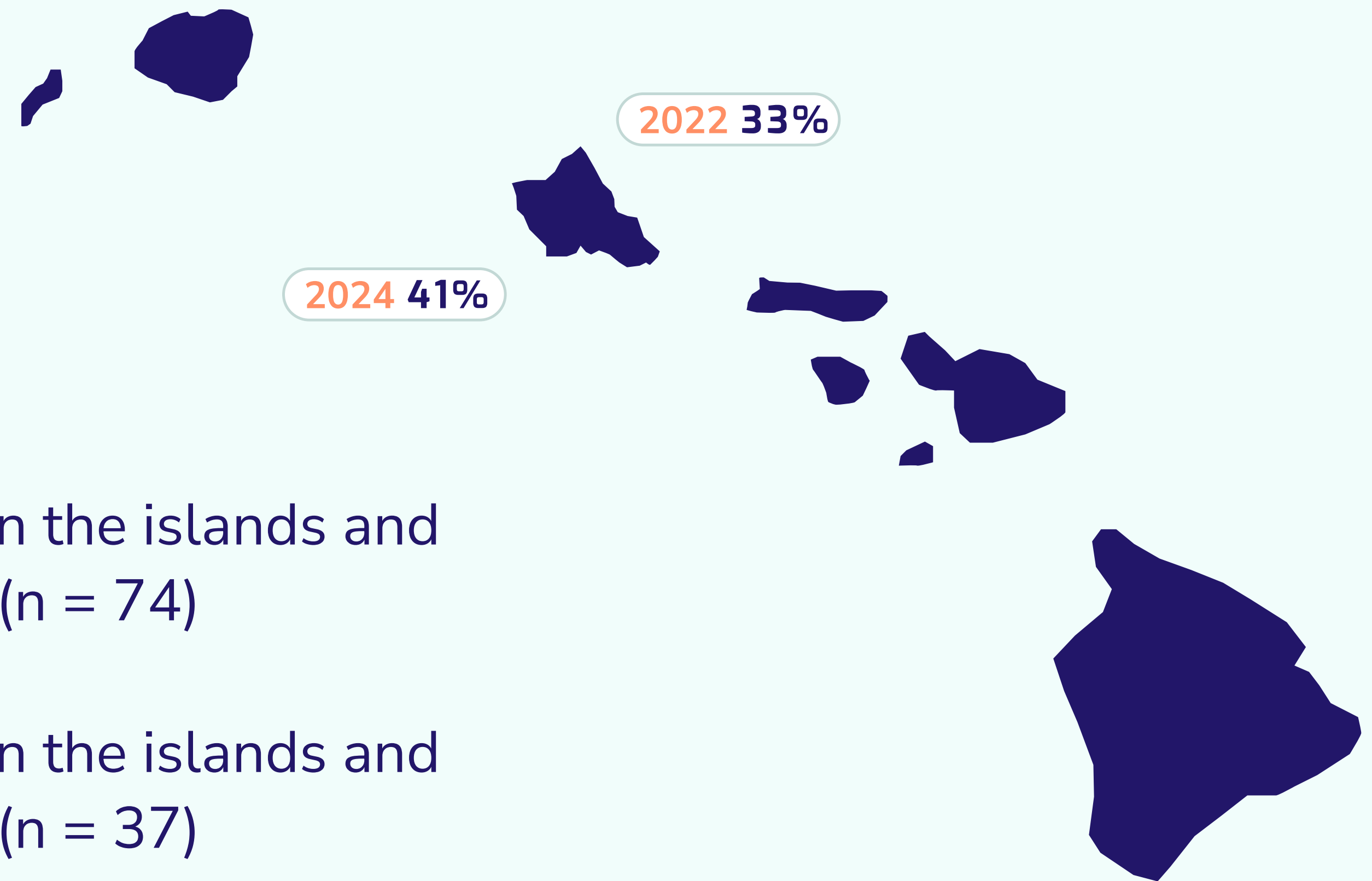


:: “I intend to stay in Hawai‘i permanently.”

2022 survey: 62%
2024 survey: **58%**

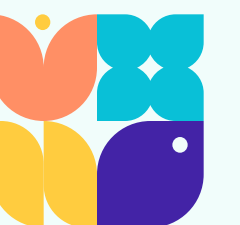


Remote work is still trending



2022: **33%** of survey respondents lived on the islands and worked for a company outside of Hawai'i (n = 74)

2024: **41%** of survey respondents lived on the islands and worked for a company outside of Hawai'i (n = 37)



Many do work for Hawai'i-based companies

2022

HST: 59%

PST: 27%

EST: 3%

Other: 7%

N/A: 3%

2024

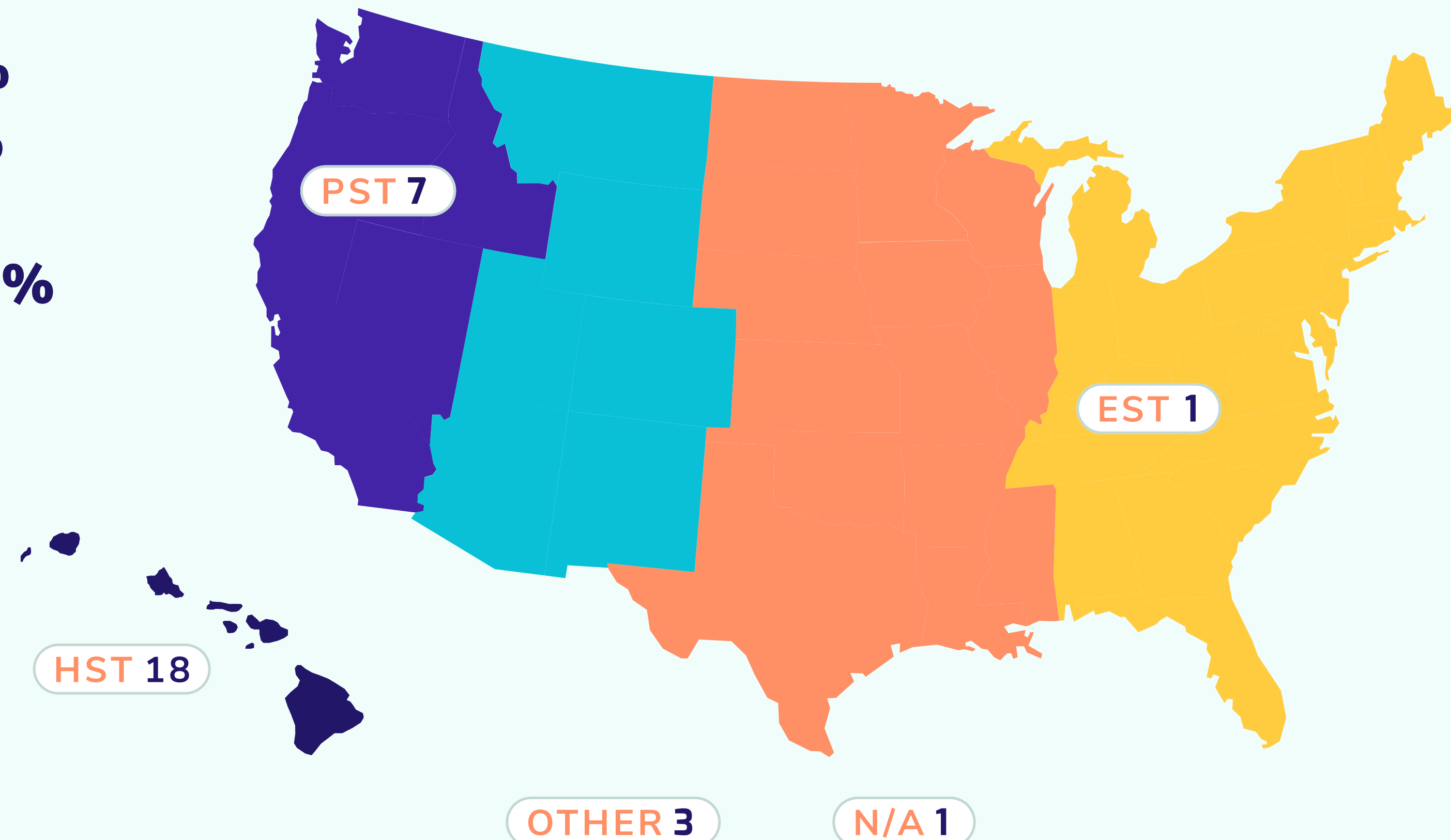
HST: 60%

PST: 23%

EST: 3%

Other: 10%

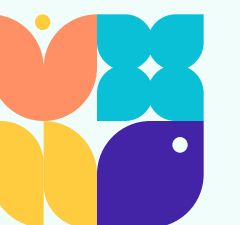
N/A: 3%



Survey respondents

2022: n = 59

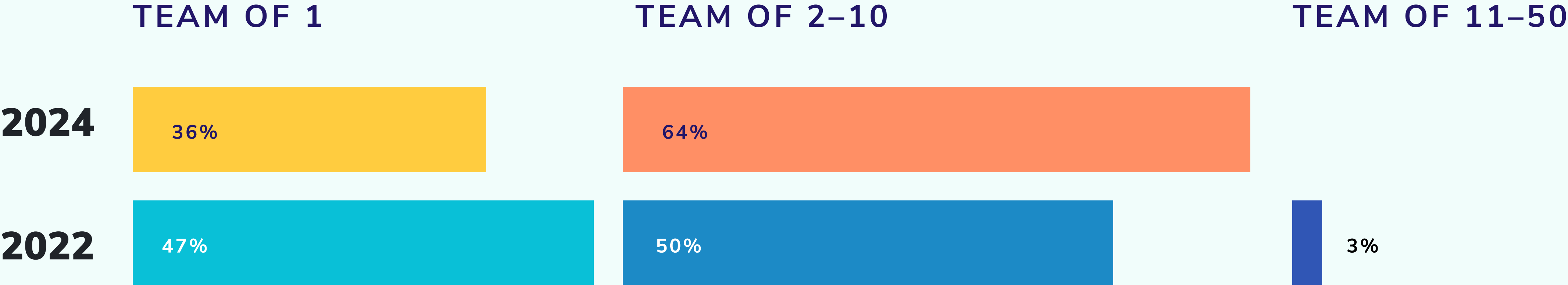
2024: n = 30



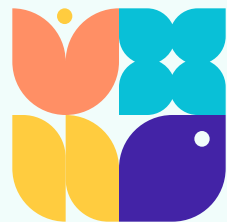
Of those based locally, many do still work as a team of 1 – though some teams have grown

Source: interview data

Hawai‘i-based companies



Survey respondents
2024: n = 14
2022: n = 34



Average salaries remain a challenge

\$110,203

Average in Hawai'i

Based on 3 salaries taken from job postings on Indeed within a 36-month period (updated November 19, 2025).

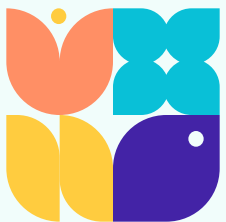
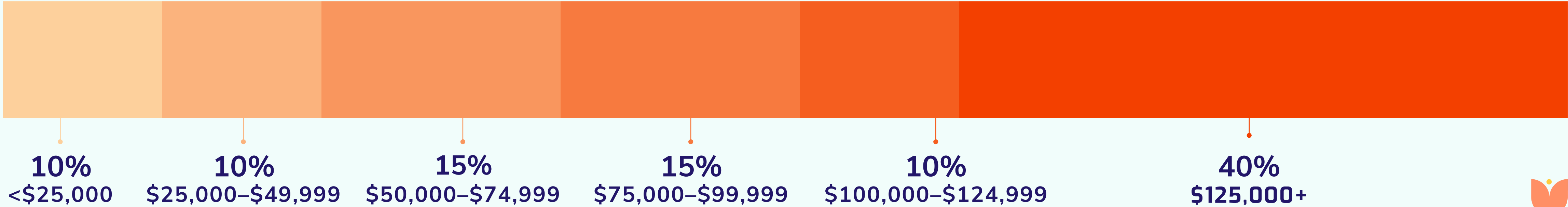
vs

\$121,196

National Average

Based on 968 salaries taken from job postings on Indeed within a 36-month period (updated December 8, 2025).

Salary range of survey respondents working in UX



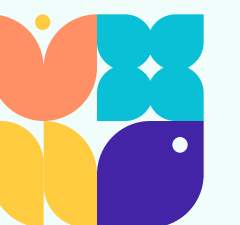
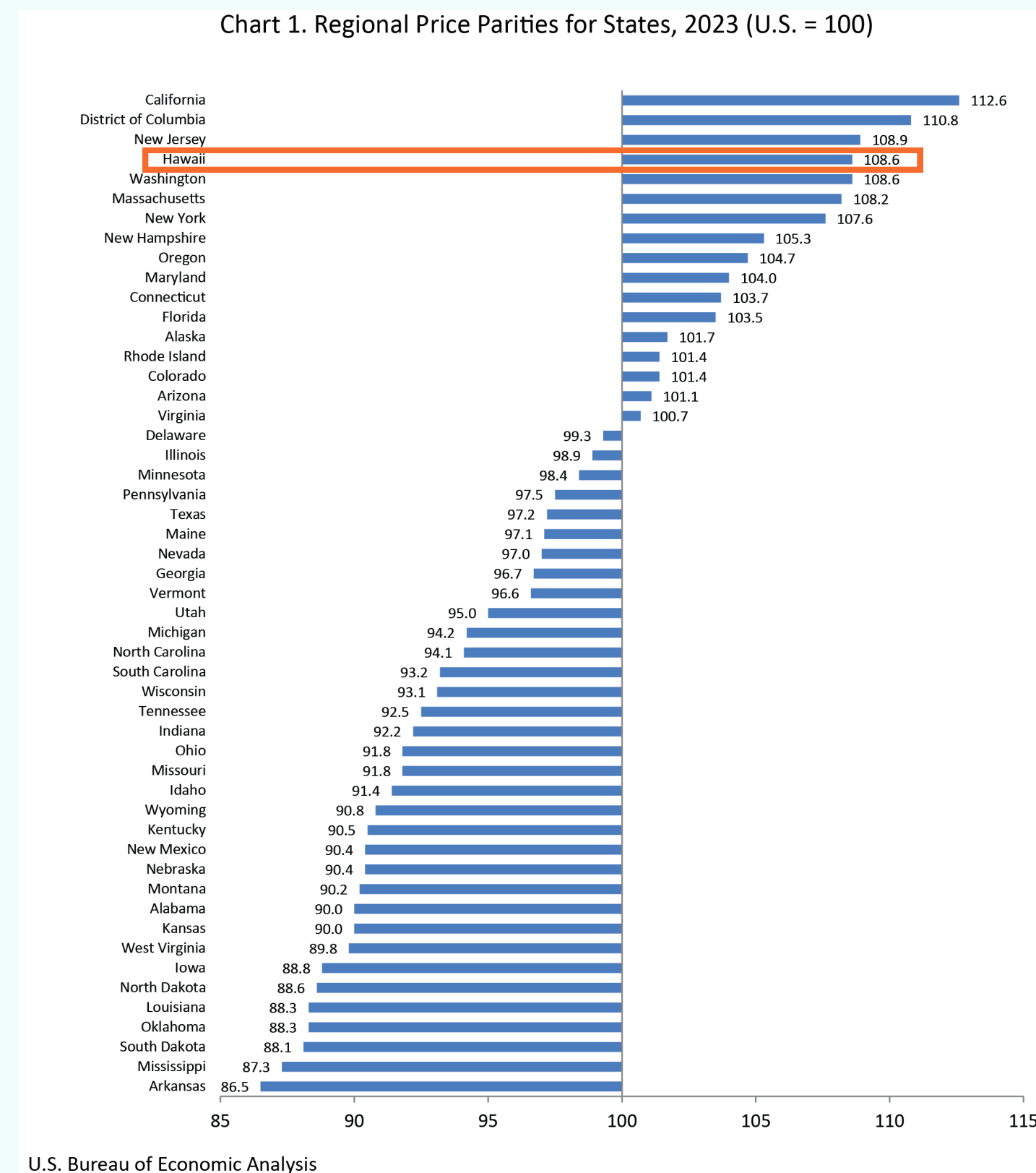
UNDERSTANDING OUR DIGITAL LANDSCAPE WITHIN HAWAII'S ECONOMY



Systemic influences continue to impact doing business in Hawai'i

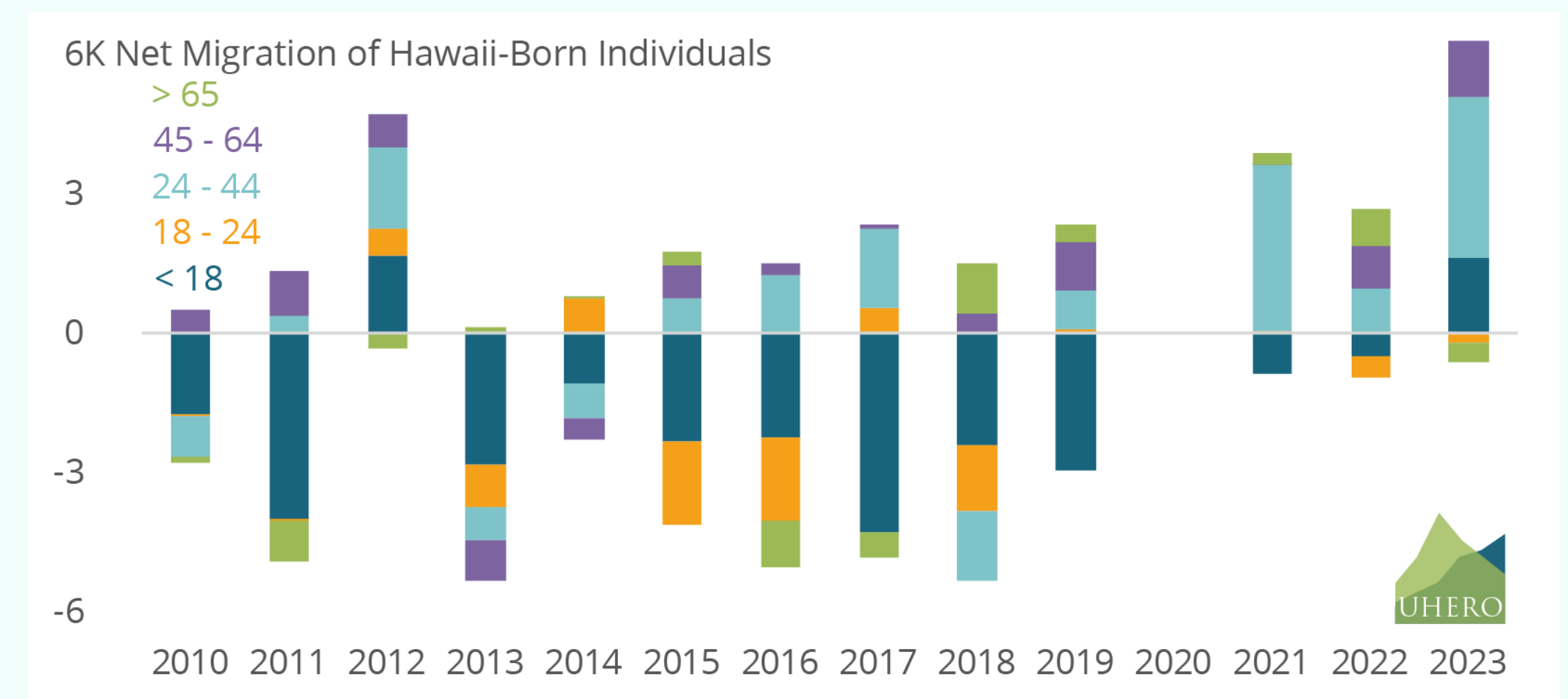
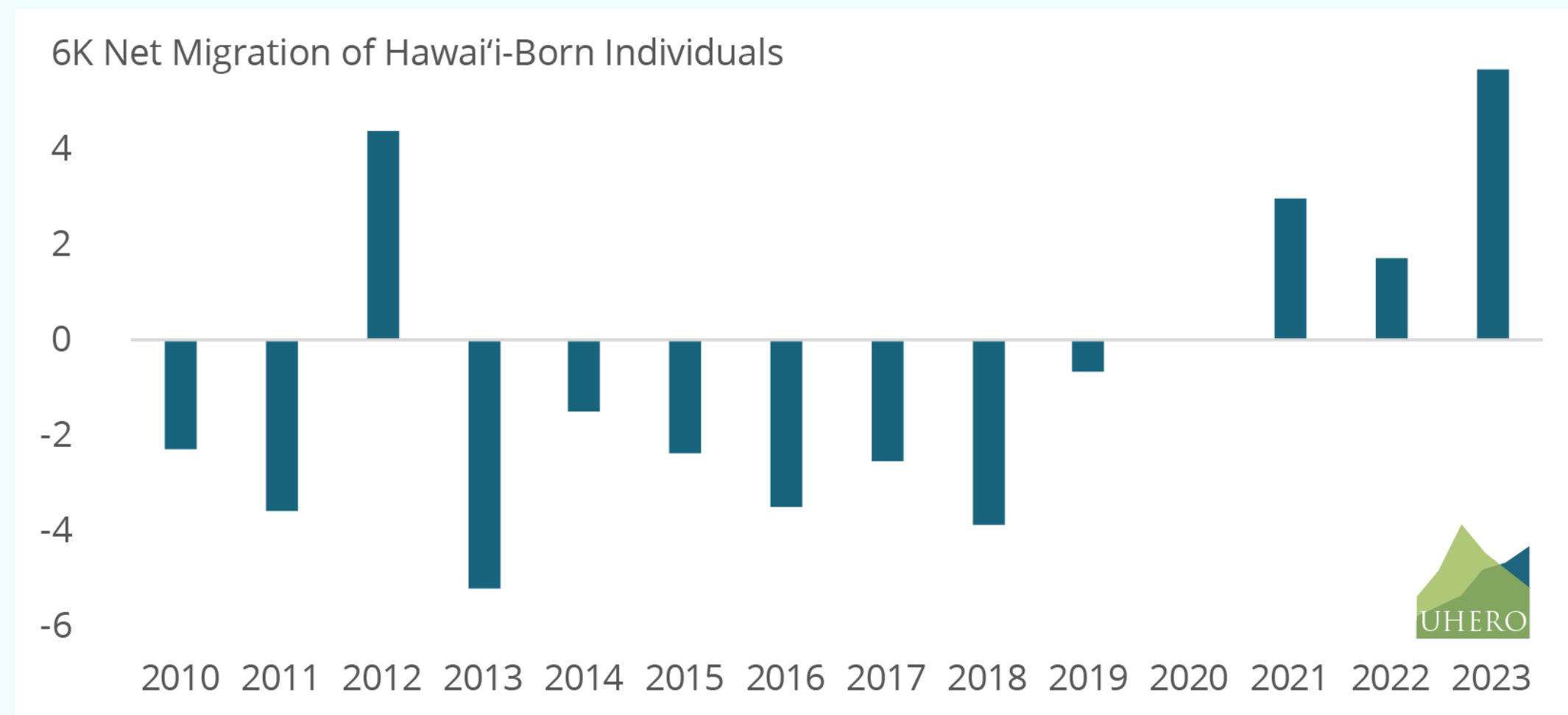
According to research by CNBC, Hawai'i is ranked 49th for business due to challenges such as infrastructure, cost of doing business, and access to capital.

In 2023, the cost of living in Hawai'i was 8.6% higher than the U.S. national average, yet our average annual salary was 14.7% lower than the national average.

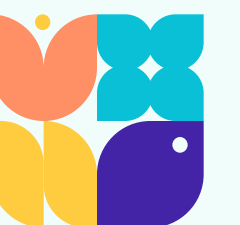


Systemic influences continue to impact working professionals in Hawai‘i

Outmigration of Hawai‘i-born residents has continued. More recently, however, there’s also been a positive change of working age professionals (note 24–44 and 45–64 age groups) returning to the islands.



<https://uhero.hawaii.edu/who-is-moving-in-and-out-understanding-migration-trends-in-hawaii/>



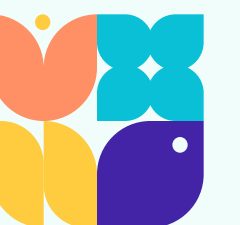
Many cite systemic barriers for companies, including hiring and talent challenges

At the same time, we heard some promising signals:

There's a growing—if slowly—UX landscape.

There's growing interest in creating internal teams.

More local businesses are interested in UX as a practice.

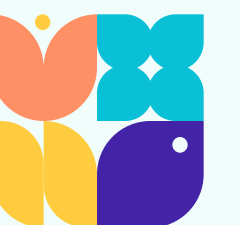


WHAT'S NEW IN 2024/2025?



What nuances did we uncover?

- In 2022, there was less mention of startups or **emerging tech** within the UX community—but that's **starting to shift**.
- We're now seeing signs of **momentum**, with more local startups gaining traction and UX becoming a more visible priority.
- According to Startup Blink's 2024 report indexing 1,400+ cities worldwide, Honolulu rose 24 spots in global rankings (at #313) for startup ecosystems. At the same time, in 2025 the ranking dropped to #347, with 65 startups in Honolulu.
- **One team grew** from 2 people to 10 between 2022 and 2024. Another team is bringing UX in-house. (Source: interviews)
- New granularity in participants' comments mention **specialist roles** in UX, a sign of UX maturity in organizations.



Signs of momentum

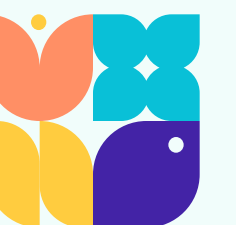
What changes have you noticed for UX in Hawai'i in the past 2 years?

38%

of respondents mentioned seeing the UX community and interest in UX grow on island

“It feels like the community is **growing exponentially**. I’ve noticed a lot more involvement with the general tech community and an **increased interest in UX** within that bubble.”

– Survey, UX professional



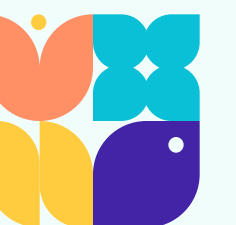
Rapid changes in the field

“It’s going to be a rollercoaster, we have to exercise both our brains. With AI, and certain aspects of our job becoming commoditized, figuring out where you stand.”

– Interview, SVP of UX

“Today’s environment become really good at AI prompting, and getting the result you want from AI.”

– Interview, CEO & Founder



People are doing UX without calling it UX

Team members are sometimes “individuals without UX training, but UX interest.”

– Interview, Professor of Design

“The government does UXR but they don’t necessarily realize they’re doing UXR.”

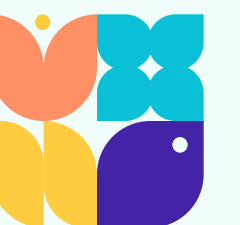
– Interview, Lead UX Designer

“A lot of the UX team is made up of the marketing team.”

– Interview, Senior Manager of Product

11 out of 37 survey respondents said some of their responsibilities included UX work, though their roles may not reflect this:

- Engineering: 4
- Visual/graphic design: 4
- Product management: 3



HOW MIGHT WE CONTINUE TO GROW UX IN HAWAII?



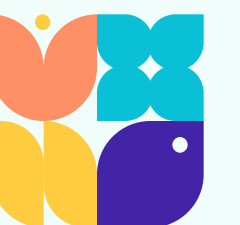
Our goals from the 2022 report



**Inspire local
business
leaders to
hire UX
professionals**

**Create
opportunities for
people new to
UX to gain
experience**

**Host
collaborative
events to
strengthen the
UX community**



What we've accomplished: Jan 2023–now

Increased awareness about UX and our community

- Presented *UX 101 for Businesses* at Honolulu Tech Week, 2024 and 2025
- Began offering consulting and UX talent search services for businesses

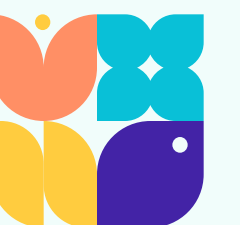
Tabled at events to increase awareness about our community

For tech and creative communities:

- Eahou Fest
September 13, 2024
- East Meets West 2024 & 2025
March 14–15, 2024, April 15–16, 2025
- We Write Hawai'i
July 26, 2025

For government and economic development:

- Capitol Connect: Hawai'i Tech Ecosystem
April 21, 2025



Supported opportunities...

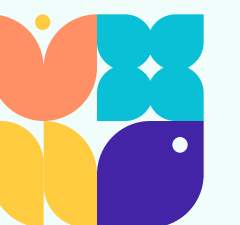
...for tech economy development

- Thought partner in first cohorts of Pi'ikū Co. (formerly Circular Design Internship)
- Partner projects and events with Code with Aloha, AI Hawai'i, Honolulu Tech Network, Honolulu BitDevs, PyHawaii and Hawai'i Center for AI

...to increase exposure to the field of UX

Tabled at events for students:

- Hawai'i Esports Invitational
- Stevenson Middle School Career Expo
- Multiple career fairs with the University of Hawai'i campuses



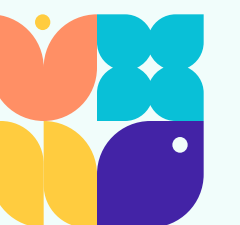
Hosted events for...

...skill building

- Company spotlight with RVCN
- *Creating Healthier Product Team Alignment Through Play*
- *Elevating Your Interviews: Design Challenges and Best Practices*
- *Thriving as a Freelance UX Consultant in a Remote World*
- *Using Content Creation to Propel Your Design Career*
- *Designing AI Experiences: Intelligence as a Feature*, in collaboration with PyHawaii and Hawai'i Center for AI

...community building

- Pau hana on O'ahu and neighbor islands
- Collab socials with AI Hawai'i, Honolulu Tech Network, Honolulu BitDevs, Honolulu Board Games
- Co-hosted Designer Walks with Holoholo
- Virtual game nights
- Community dialogues





**Together, we can
achieve even more...**

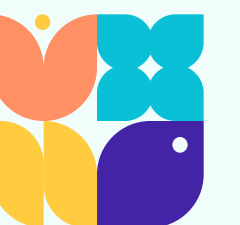
In 2024, we asked, “What can we do as individuals and as a community?”

Here's what we heard:

More education about UX, both for individuals and for businesses

Continue events and de-silo the creative community

Help with job opportunities, create business opportunities, and become advocates for UX



Top responses from our 2025 conference

Education (108 total upvotes of 21 entries)

- “Continuing education courses with industry professionals” (18 upvotes)
- “A hands on workshop” (18 upvotes)
- “Certification in UX Design, interactive workshops, talks around UX in specific industries” (18 upvotes)

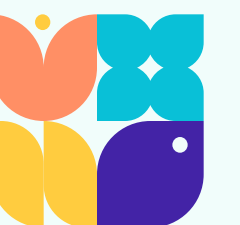
Advocacy (82 total upvotes of 28 entries)

- “Showcase how other big companies such as Google, Amazon etc. invest in UX and their success that comes from it” (9 upvotes)
- “Lead with data—business/project outcomes of businesses that invest in UX” (8 upvotes)
- “More research and sharing of those findings to justify the value of UX” (7 upvotes)

Job opportunities (81 total upvotes of 14 entries)

- “Make it easier to find a local UX job” (18 upvotes)
- “Job board for companies that will actually hire people in Hawai‘i” (11 upvotes)
- “Experiences! Paid work experiences, that pay well! Give our people experiences and pay them to thrive” (10 upvotes)

**Thank you for the
great ideas on helping
our community
continue to grow!**



THANK YOU

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APPENDIX

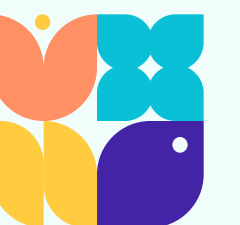


Research methodology: Participatory action research session

We conducted a Participatory Action Research (PAR) session through an in-person workshop at the 2024 UXHI Conference. This collaborative session engaged 57+ UX professionals and allies to reflect on the state of UX in Hawai'i. We asked participant-researchers to discuss and record responses to the following questions:

- What's working well for UX in Hawai'i?
- What's working not well for UX in Hawai'i?
- What can be improved?

The goal was to co-create insights and solutions grounded in real, lived experiences within our community.



Research methodology: Community surveys

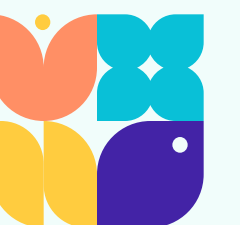
We also distributed a remote, unmoderated survey targeting the UX community and individuals with a passion for UX who have a connection to Hawai'i. This survey allowed us to gather a wide range of direct perspectives from those actively engaged with or invested in the local UX ecosystem. By combining open-ended questions with quantitative measures, we not only captured personal experiences and opinions, but also identified patterns and trends across the broader community.

While we initially launched an additional version of the survey—one tailored specifically for business leaders, the response rate for that audience was limited, and therefore not included in our final analysis.

It's important to also note that percentages are not provided for direct comparison between the 2022 and 2024 reports, due to a difference in the number of survey responses.

2022: n = 74

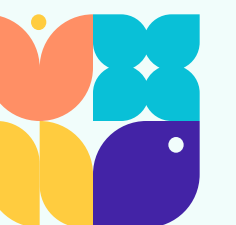
2024: n = 37



Research methodology:

Interviews

Remote user interviews were conducted over the span of 2 months with a diverse group of participants, including UX professionals, business leaders, and educators in the field. These conversations helped us explore different perspectives on the state of UX in Hawai'i—how it's evolving, what gaps still exist, and what opportunities lie ahead. By speaking directly with people working across industries and roles, we were able to gather rich, nuanced insights to inform our findings.



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